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Whether it's processor speeds, hard drive capacities or sleek displays, almost every computer component has evolved and broken new ground, thanks to constant technological innovations. In contrast, input devices have remained unchanged for nearly two decades—they've seen a few minor cosmetic changes, but no real technological innovations.

It's only in the past couple of years that new technologies have made their way into input devices. With industry bigwigs such as Intel and Microsoft making headway into our living rooms, the need for better human interface devices arises. Recent product line-ups from major input device manufacturers stand testimony to this shift, and reflect their desire to capture new markets.

While Logitech and Microsoft have traditionally been the major players, many small brands have emerged over the years. These smaller brands offer devices at throwaway prices, and make buying decisions difficult. Also, vendors have taken up a solution-centric approach, thereby bundling keyboards and mice as desktop kits. This cuts packaging costs, delivers more value to the customer, and also makes it simple for the customer to choose. Of course, standalone keyboards and mice are still available.

In this comparison test, we tested around fifteen combo kits, fifteen standalone keyboards and 23 mice, from all the major brands available in Indian market. Based on the technology used, the "combo kits" category was classified into Wired and Cordless. The Mice category shows a clear distinction in terms of their usage—for desktops or laptops—whereas the standalone keyboards we received were all wired.

You might ask at this point, "What's the big deal about keyboards and mice?" Well, there's a lot to it! When buying a PC, we tend to pay a lot of attention to the hardware configuration—processor, hard drive, graphics card, etc. Keyboards and mice are generally picked up like potatoes and

tomatoes—we settle for just anything. What people forget is that we interface with our systems using these devices, and these components are therefore the most utilised. Another thing to remember is that apart from being good-looking, input devices have to be comfortable to use, or you're going to end up with aching joints.

You also need to bear in mind that keyboards and mice are rarely ever "upgraded"—they are only changed if they stop working. Here's where we come in—read this test thoroughly and use it to make a good buying decision. Keep in mind, however, that one person's passion can be another's poison, so actually getting a feel for what you're buying is of utmost importance!

KEYBOARDS

The standalone keyboards category covered products ranging from a paltry Rs 260 for the entry-level Genius keyboard to Rs 4,995 for the Logitech Gaming keyboard. Almost all the products in this category were wired.

Features

iBall's Power Key designer keyboard had the most number of features. The keyboard is cramped with extra buttons that give it a "busy" kind of look. The black colour, with the red "i" key, gives it the special iBall treatment. Apart from the standard keys, you get about 32 extra keys for various functions. The keyboard features all the regular multimedia and Internet hotkeys for one-touch operation.

To stand apart from the crowd, iBall decided to integrate keys for controlling MS Office applications—Word, Excel, Power Point, and Calendar. Other standard Windows functions such as Cut, Copy and Paste can also be achieved via dedicated keys. Except for the Office hotkeys, all others work without installing any drivers. The keyboard also has a USB port that you can use to connect other devices, as well as a scroll wheel that blinks different colours while you work.

Similar to the iBall was the Tech-com SSD-KB-990 keyboard. This keyboard is cramped with hotkeys for functions that you might never use—the SSD-KB-990 has 49 extra hotkeys! Apart from the standard, multimedia and

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Internet hotkeys, the keyboard comes with one touch-keys for Windows Office XP. Tech-com has gone a step forward, integrating a scroll-pad—quite handy in Excel and during Internet browsing.

Most of the hotkeys work without installing the software, but if you buy this keyboard, we'd recommend that you install the bundled software.

Logitech was represented by two keyboards, the standard entry-level keyboard and the top-of-the-line gaming keyboard, the G5. While there is hardly anything to write home about regarding the standard classic keyboard, it happens to be the best vanilla keyboard out there.

The G5 gaming keyboard, on the other hand, is the best standalone keyboard we have come across thus far! It has fantastic build quality, a plush feel, and a host of features to rock your games. There are 18 programmable keys in three modes that give 54 combinations to play around with. The keyboard is backlit and features a button to switch it off. The most interesting aspect of this keyboard is the programmable LCD display—a first-ever for a keyboard! You also get two USB



The display screen of the Logitech G15 gaming keyboard

ports on the keyboard so you can attach other devices. The software bundled with the G5 for programming macros is fantastic—simple and very useful.

Microsoft's Comfort curve 2000 was the only keyboard in the whole test from the software giant. This was the probably the best looking standalone keyboard, not counting the Logitech G5. Apart from good looks and a unique, comfortable design, the Comfort curve